

支持“间隔年青年”身份建构的产品服务体系设计—— 以“叙室”卡牌为例

Narrative Room: A Product-Service System for Facilitating Identity Construction among Gap-Year Youth

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Year 2026/ PSSD Master Degree Research Thesis



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This research aims to develop
a card-based product-service system
that supports Chinese gap-year youth
in community-led coworking spaces
by facilitating identity exploration,
social connection, and actionable self-
narratives through shared storytelling
and peer interaction.

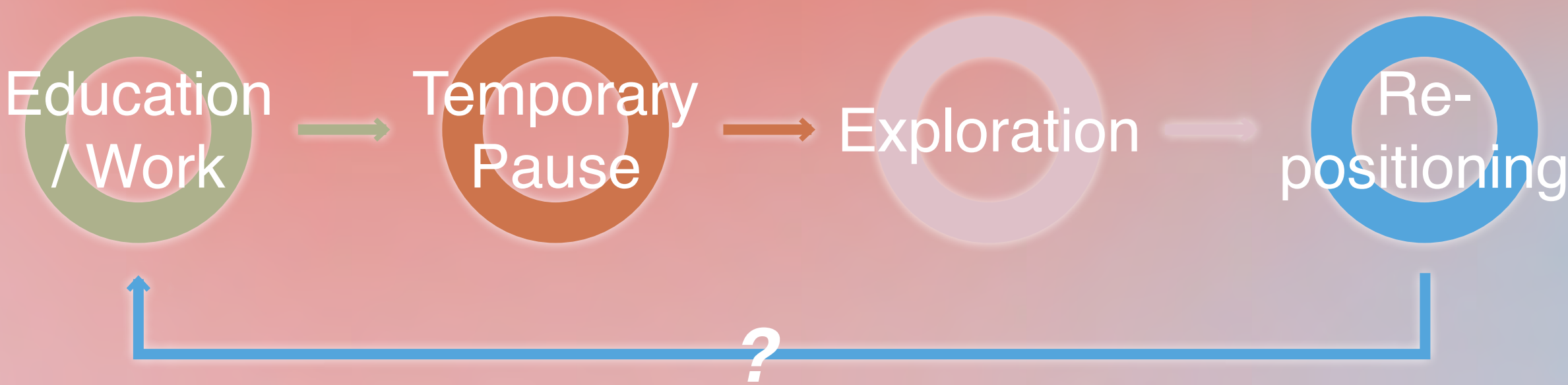
- Approach
- User
- Context
- Content
- Mechanism

What is & Why "Chinese Gap-Year Youth"?

What is it?

Chinese gap-year youth refers to young people who temporarily step away from the standard education-to-work trajectory and enter a transitional stage of self-exploration.

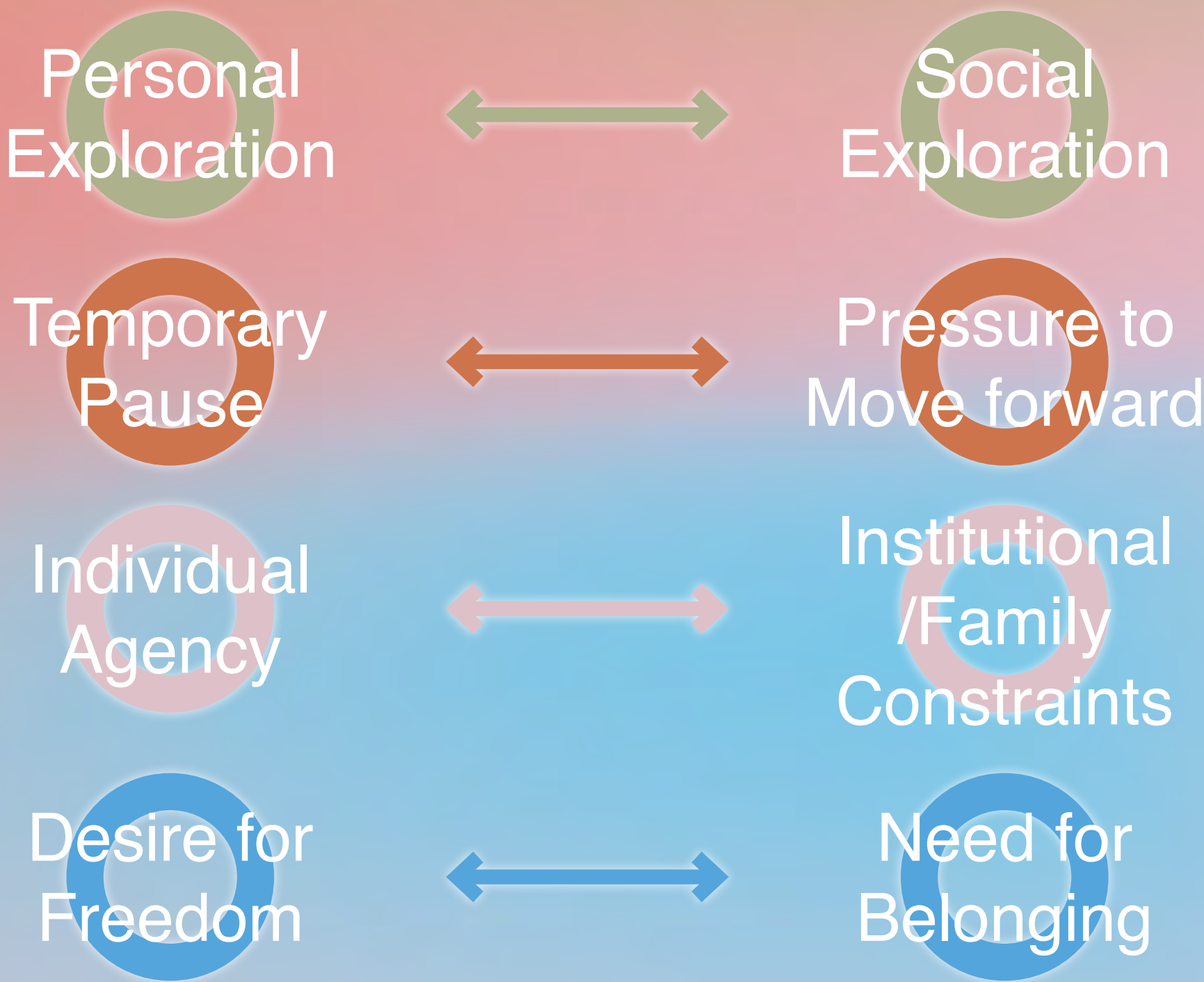
- Non-linear transition from study to work
- Exploration of identity, career, and lifestyle possibilities
- Uncertainty between “leaving” and “returning”
- Negotiation with family expectations, institutional rules, and economic realities



A non-linear transition shaped by exploration, pressure, and the need for support.

Why does it matter?

In China, taking a gap year is not simply a free lifestyle choice. It is shaped by structural pressure, time anxiety, and unequal access to support.



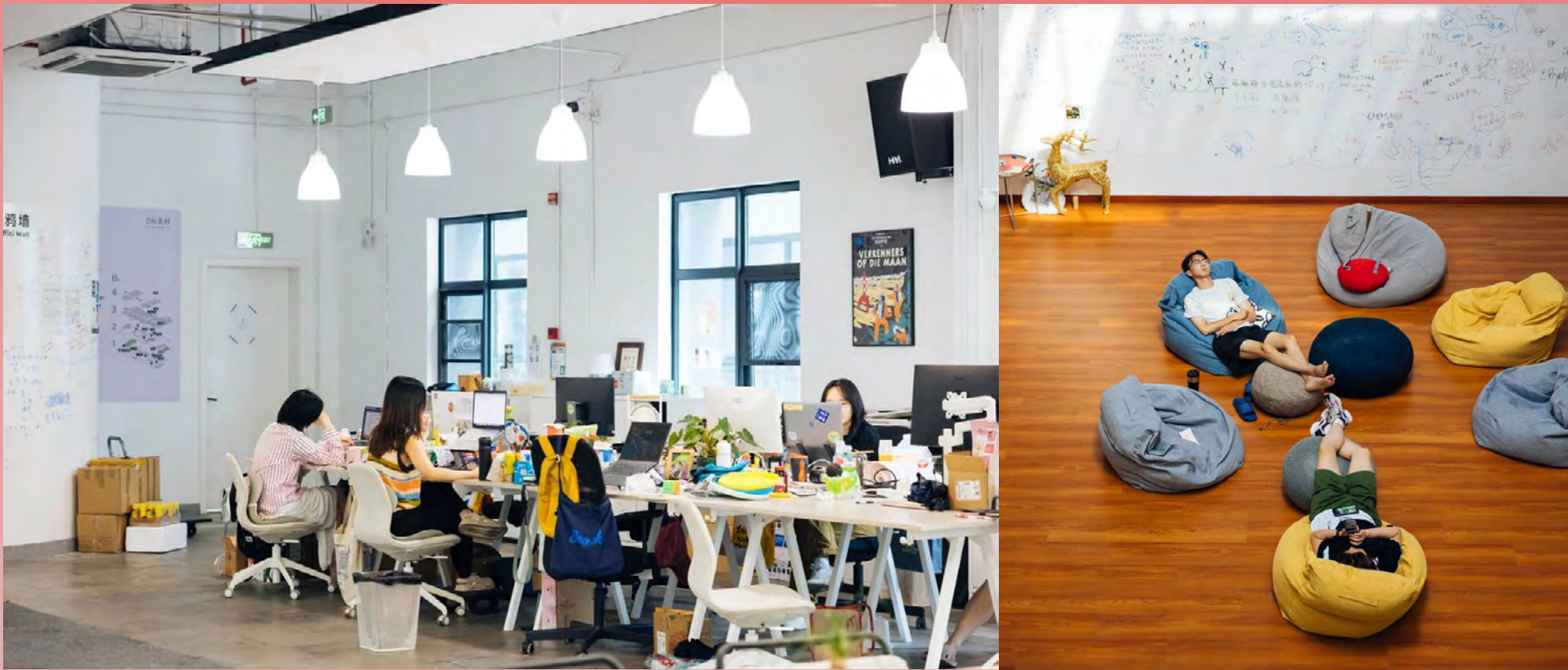
What is & Why "Community-Led Co-Working Space"?

What is it?

A *community-led co-working space* is more than a shared workplace. It is a locally embedded social space where people gather through peer support, shared activities, and mutual exchange.

Space as Social Infrastructure

Work Learn Share Connect



DN Yucun Community, Anji, Zhejiang
Source: DNCN Official WeChat Account

Why does it matter?

opportunities

Peer Support

Weak-tie Networks

Shared Activities

Local Belonging

Informal Exchange

tensions

High Mobility

Unstable Relationships

Event-based Interaction

Unequal Participation

Fear of Overexposure

A community-led co-working space is not only a workplace, but a relational field for narrative exchange, resonance, and social support.

What is & Why "Card-based Tools"?

What is it?

Cards function as “*boundary objects*” between people, objects, and meanings.

They combine a stable physical format with open-ended visual and verbal cues, making them both repeatable and flexible across different social contexts.



OH Cards as an example of projective card systems
Image source: monascent.com

Why does it matter?

Safer Self-Expression

Cards allow participants to speak through an object, reducing the pressure of direct self-disclosure.

Shared Focus in Dialogue

Cards placed on the table create a visible “conversation map,” helping participants focus on the same symbols and meanings.

Visual Memory & Action Traces

Selecting, moving, and keeping cards leaves physical traces of reflection, making the process easier to recall and continue.

Cards are not decorative props, but micro-interfaces that make narratives, emotions, and relationships visible, shareable, and actionable.

Paradox

Apparent Opportunities

Open and flexible space

Frequent community events

Shared interests and weak ties

Underlying Tensions

Youth still face identity uncertainty and lack **clear direction**

Temporary encounters do not automatically become **sustained relationships**

Emotional resonance and **deeper support** are difficult to maintain

Research Question

How can a product-service system, using card-based tool as a medium, support identity exploration and social connection among Chinese gap-year youth in community-led coworking spaces?

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Objectives

- 1 Understand the Context
To explore the identity construction patterns of Chinese gap-year youth in digital nomad and coworking communities.
- 2 Identify Narrative Mechanisms
To examine how card-based interaction can trigger self-narratives, future imagination, and shared storytelling.
- 3 Develop the System
To design a card-based product-service system that supports identity exploration, resonance, and peer interaction.
- 4 Evaluate the Intervention
To assess how the system facilitates social connection, self-understanding, and small-step action.

Methods

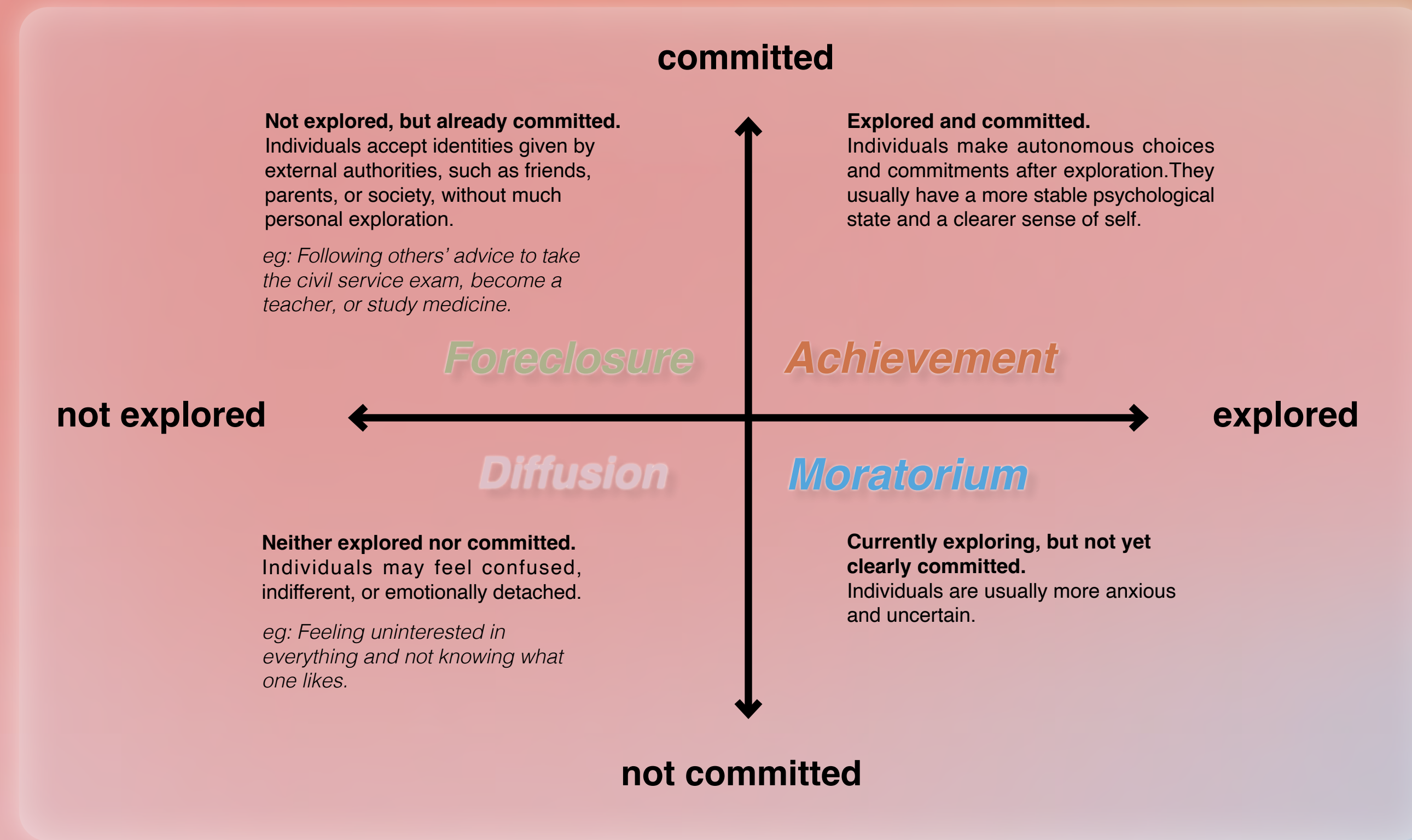
- literature review
case study
semi-structured interviews
- prototype-based workshops
semi-structured interviews
field observation
- semi-structured interviews
prototype-based workshops
- prototype design & test

What is "Identity Construction" & "Self-Narratives"?

02 Research & Output

What is it?

Marcia's Theory of Identity Status

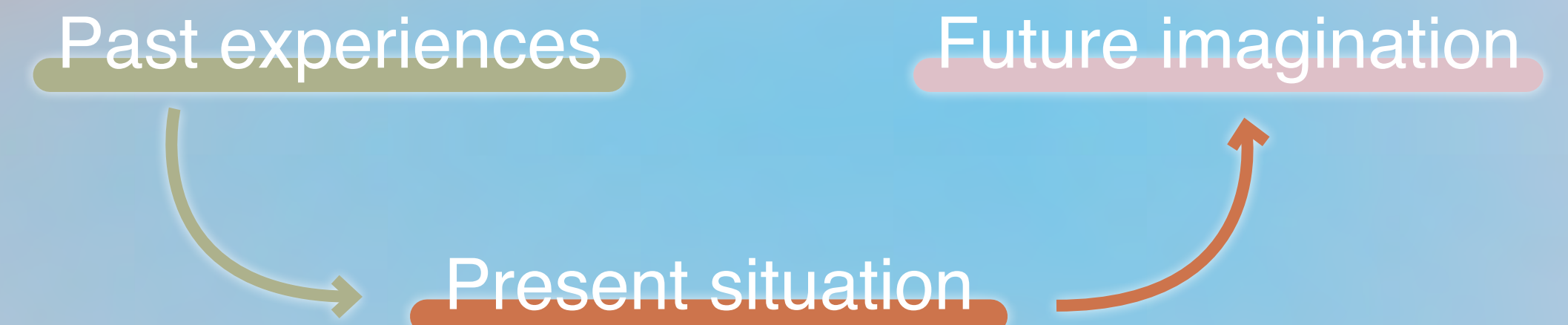


Marcia, J.E. (1966). Development and validation of ego-identity status. *Journal of personality and social psychology*, 3(5), 551.

Narrative Identity: Self as a Story

"Narrative identity is an internalized and evolving life story that integrates the reconstructed past and imagined future, giving the self a sense of unity and purpose."

—McAdams & McLean, 2013



Identity construction is not only an internal psychological process, but also a narrative and social process that can be supported through designed tools and community interaction.

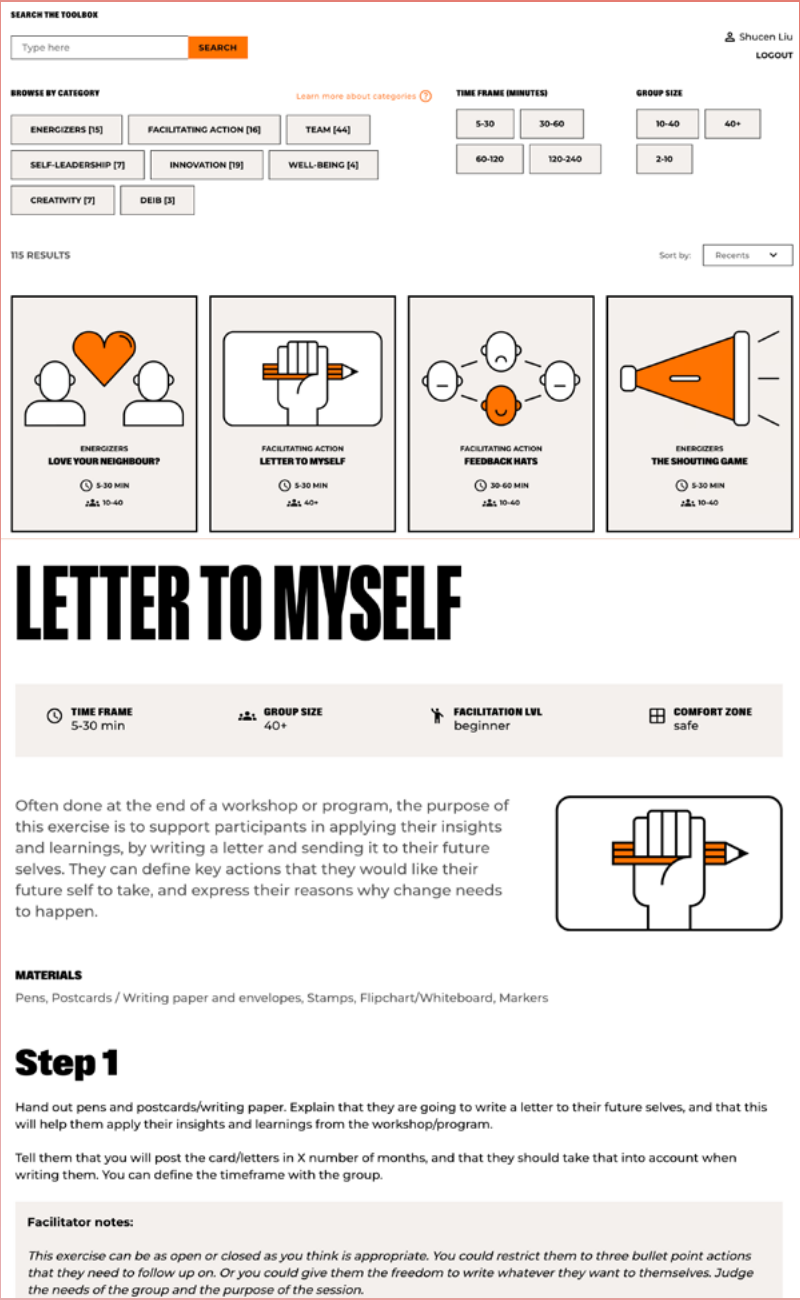
From Card-based Tools to a Product Service System

OH Cards
Safe self-expression
Projective card system
Symbolic images
+ personal projection



Hyper Island Toolbox

Micro-rituals
Facilitation toolkit
Modular flow
+ reflection
+ action commitment



We're Not Really Strangers

Layered self-disclosure
Narrative card game
Layered questions
+ progressive self-disclosure



Airport New Village Museum

Spatialized community memory
Community narrative practice
Local memory
+ spatial storytelling
+ resident participation



What is & Why "Liangzhu Culture Village" as the Field Site?

What is it?

Liangzhu Culture Village is a low-density, culturally rich community in Hangzhou, where residential life, cultural resources, public activities, and light workspaces overlap.

Why does it matter?

Liangzhu provides a suitable field site for studying how transitional youth seek identity anchors, social support, and opportunities for small-scale action in community settings.



Image source: WeChat Official Account “三土城市笔记”, “西游记：新浙大、新客厅、新中心”, published on 2026-04-21

Strong Cultural Identity



Heritage sites, museums, bookstores, and markets together form local cultural capital.

Multi-node Publicness



Cafés, shared offices, community lounges, lawns, and markets form open interfaces for social encounters.

Low-density Ecosystem



High greenery, slow-mobility systems, and public spaces support temporary stays and chance encounters.

Weak-centered Community



Spatial nodes are dense, yet social connections remain relatively loose.

Interviews & Field Observations

02 Research & Output

Three Rounds of User Research



Key findings

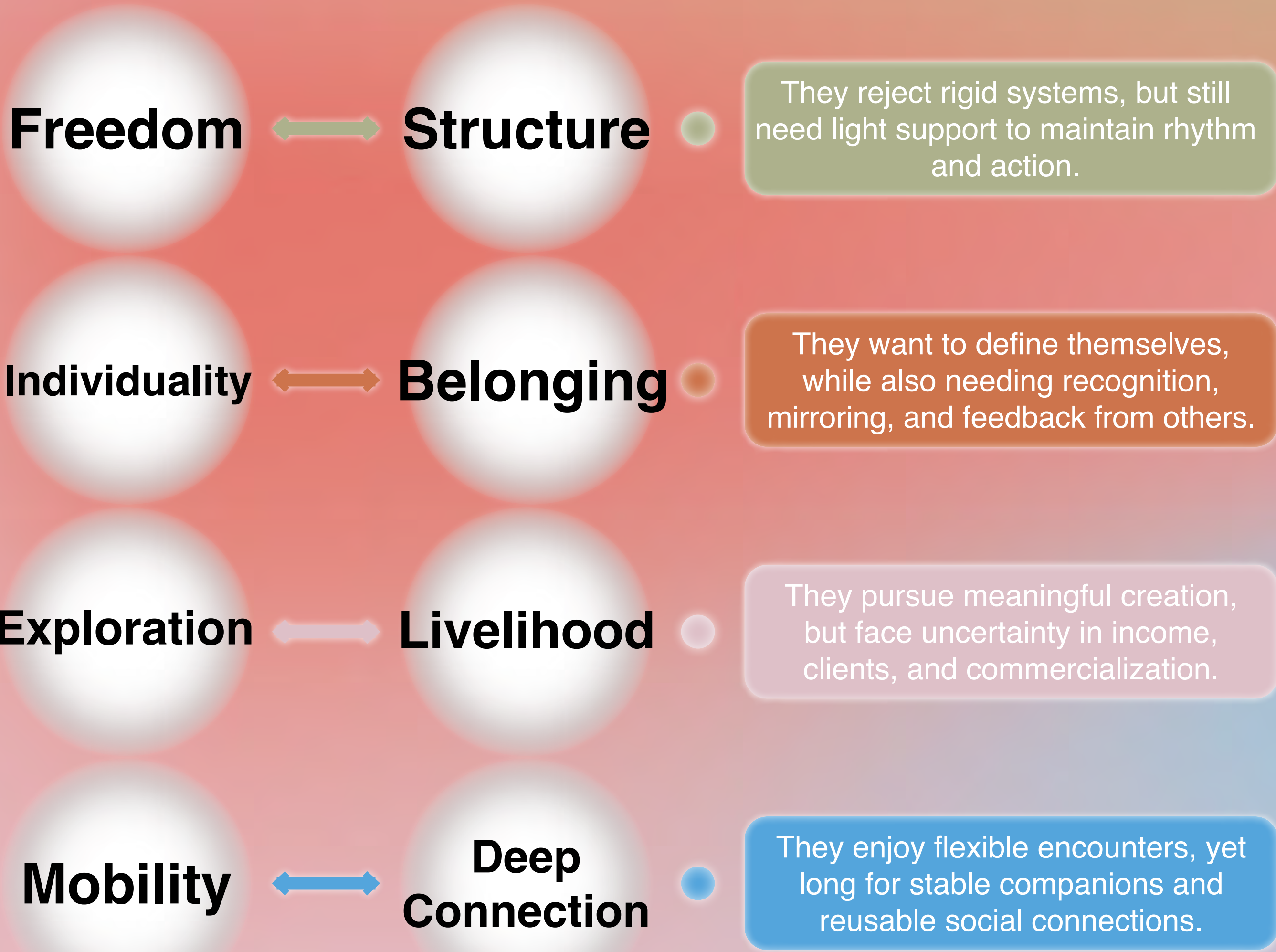
- Gap year as a response to mainstream life scripts
- **Communities** help youth rebuild **self-narratives**

- Digital nomadism as a sustainable work-life hybrid
- Preference for **purposeful, project-based social interaction**

- Freedom often comes with **disorder and uncertainty**
- **Micro-actions and rituals** help rebuild rhythm and confidence

Key Insights & Design Opportunities

Core Tensions



Design Opportunities

- Support Narrative Initiation**
Use cards to help participants describe their current state, emotions, strengths, and uncertainties.
- Build Lightweight Social Structure**
Provide simple rules, prompts, and rituals to reduce the pressure of starting conversations.
- Transform Sharing into Action**
Guide participants from “talking about ideas” to “doing something small together.”
- Help Communities Accumulate Memory**
Use visualized cards, traces, and records to make social connections reviewable and reusable.

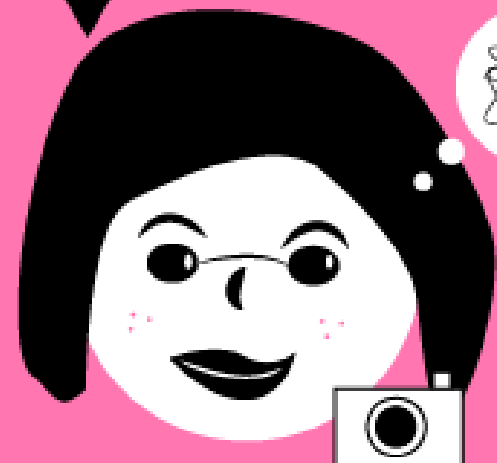
Persona

02 Research & Output

01 Transition Explorer

阿兔 我想先试着做点作品，但不知道从哪里开始，也不确定是不是我真的喜欢的方向.....

转场探索者（大学生/应届）



背景 22岁，刚行政管理专业本科毕业，不喜欢本专业，热爱摄影与剪辑，缺乏人脉与资源。

场景 准备gap 6-12个月：关注摄影/剪辑/自媒体但无作品体系，弱人脉。

痛点 信息过载，行动拖延，完美开局焦虑：家庭期待与自我怀疑并存。

心理 刷内容多，产出少：渴望但愿在安全环境试错：需要“被看见”的低风险场域。

Atu, 22
Recent Graduate
Exploring life and career directions after graduation. Needs a low-risk space to start small creative practices.

02 Post-Career Transformer

晓东 离职了，方向有，但动作卡住了。

脱职转型者（从大厂转自由职业）



背景 29岁，互联网大厂5年，厌倦了加班，主动离职，希望休整，并考虑是否走自由职业道路。

场景 离职后感到生活结构感与商业链接断裂，对外沟通少：对节奏与收入焦虑。

痛点 完美主义导致停滞：客户触点稀疏：独处久，专业孤独感。

心理 擅长分析但难以“动手发出第一条”：偏好证据与反馈驱动。

Xiaodong, 29
Former Product Manager
Leaving a high-pressure job and shifting to independent work. Needs peer feedback and light structure to take action.

03 Collaborative Creator

花花 我需要一个人能和我快速试作品，互相激发的人。

多元创作者（新闻/媒体/艺术跨界）



背景 26岁：新闻背景：有写作/剧本/播音能力但缺合作角色（导演/剪辑/演员）。

场景 项目零散，团队节奏难形成：渴望“共创火花”与展示舞台。

痛点 新连接充足但旧连接欠缺：合作门槛过高导致迟迟不开工。

心理 被图像/情绪激发，爱讲故事：需要明确分工与时间。

Huahua, 26
Media & Arts Creator
Has many creative ideas but lacks suitable partners. Needs quick co-creation, clear roles, and short-term tasks.

04 Structure Seeker

绿子 我能做，但一个人做决定太累，节奏老断。

结构寻求者（自由职业独行者）



背景 32岁，室内/平面/品牌执行等个体服务者：接单不稳，节奏起伏。

场景 工作推进靠意志：决策成本高，复盘稀疏：客户运营生疏。

痛点 一个人做决定累：无人校对：被动等待机会。

心理 执行力不错，但需要外部锚点/仪式/同伴监督。

Lüzi, 32
Independent Designer
Works independently but struggles with unstable rhythm and feedback. Needs regular co-working, review, and a companion system.

Design Concept: “ 叙室 Narrative Room”

HMW Question

Safe narrative initiation

How might we create a safe space for gap-year youth to tell their stories?

From conversation to micro-action

How might we turn temporary encounters into sustainable connections?

Visible peer recognition

How might we help participants see their strengths through others' feedback?

Replicable service toolkit

How might we make the process easy for community hosts to run and adapt?

Service Concept

“Narrative Room” is a lightweight narrative practice and connection service embedded in youth communities and co-working spaces.

It uses cards, facilitation scripts, and small rituals to create a temporary “story room” where participants can:

Tell their story



Meet peers



Take one small action

Core Value



For gap-year youth

Clarify their current state, recognize personal resources, and build initial peer support.



For community hosts

Activate social interaction, reveal hidden resources, and support future collaboration.

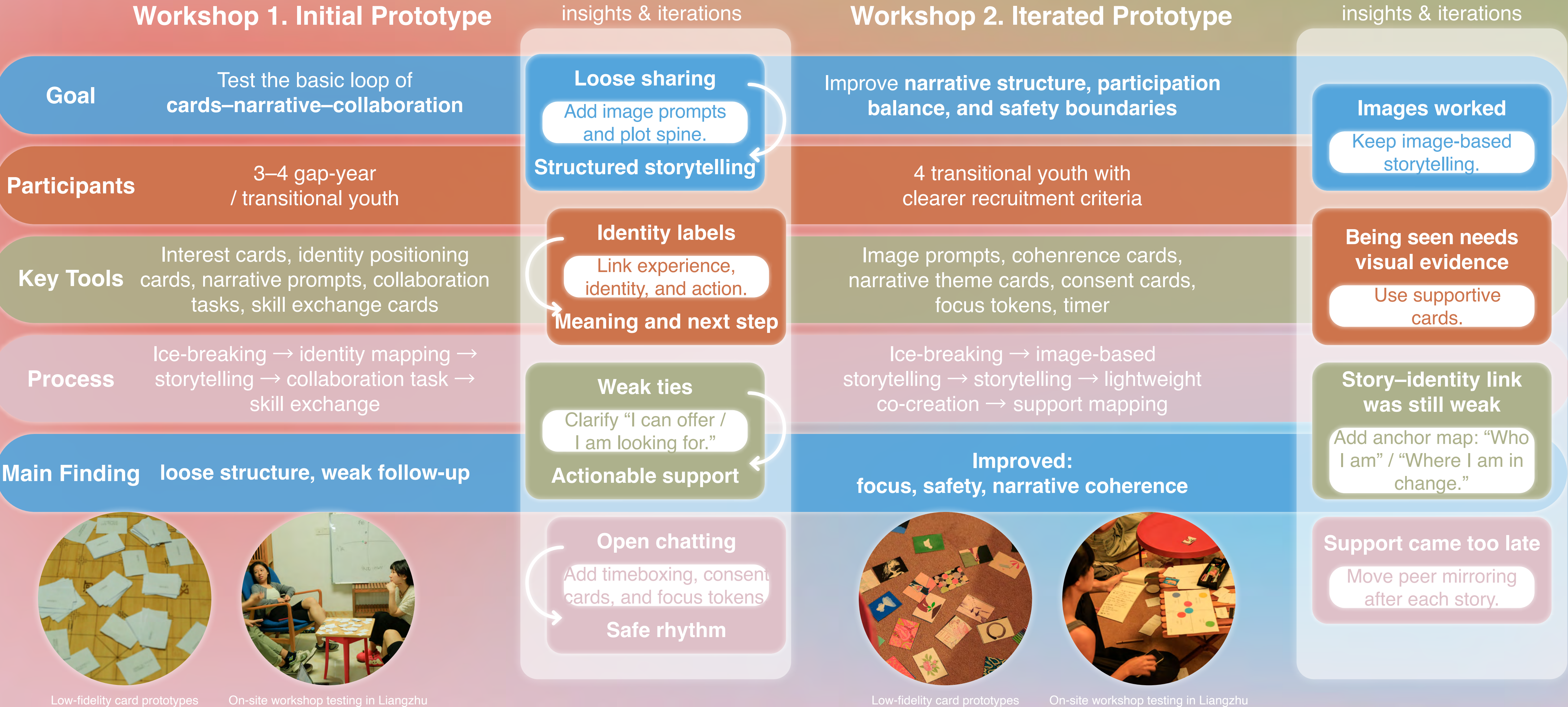


For communities

Accumulate visible stories, relationships, and reusable social connections.

Prototype-based Workshops

Two Rounds of Card-based Workshop Testing



Low-fidelity card prototypes

On-site workshop testing in Liangzhu

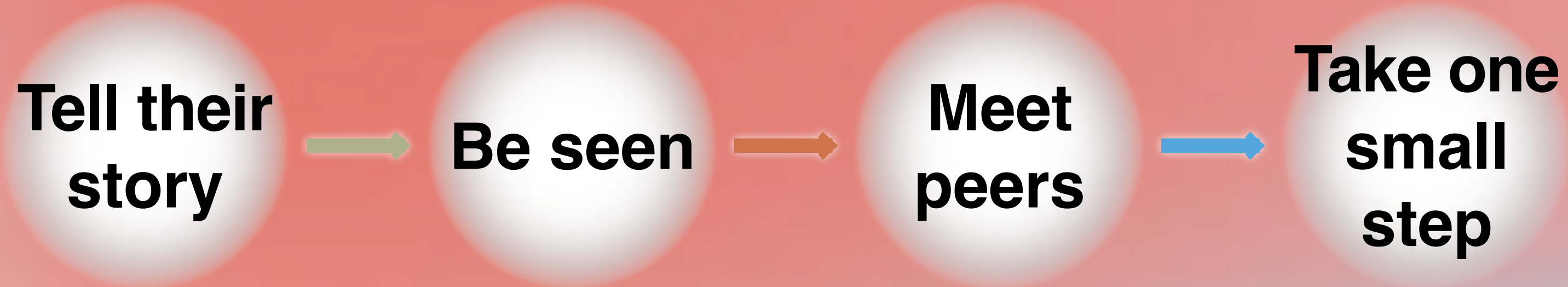
Low-fidelity card prototypes

On-site workshop testing in Liangzhu

Design Goals & Stakeholders

Design Goal

“ 叙室 Narrative Room” is designed as a deployable product-service system for gap-year and transitional youth.
It aims to provide a structured but safe space where participants can:



Design Objectives

Safe Narrative Lab

Help participants speak about their current state and turning points with clear structure and emotional boundaries.

From Inspiration Socializing to Micro-task Socializing

Turn temporary encounters into reusable support links through “I can offer / I am looking for.”

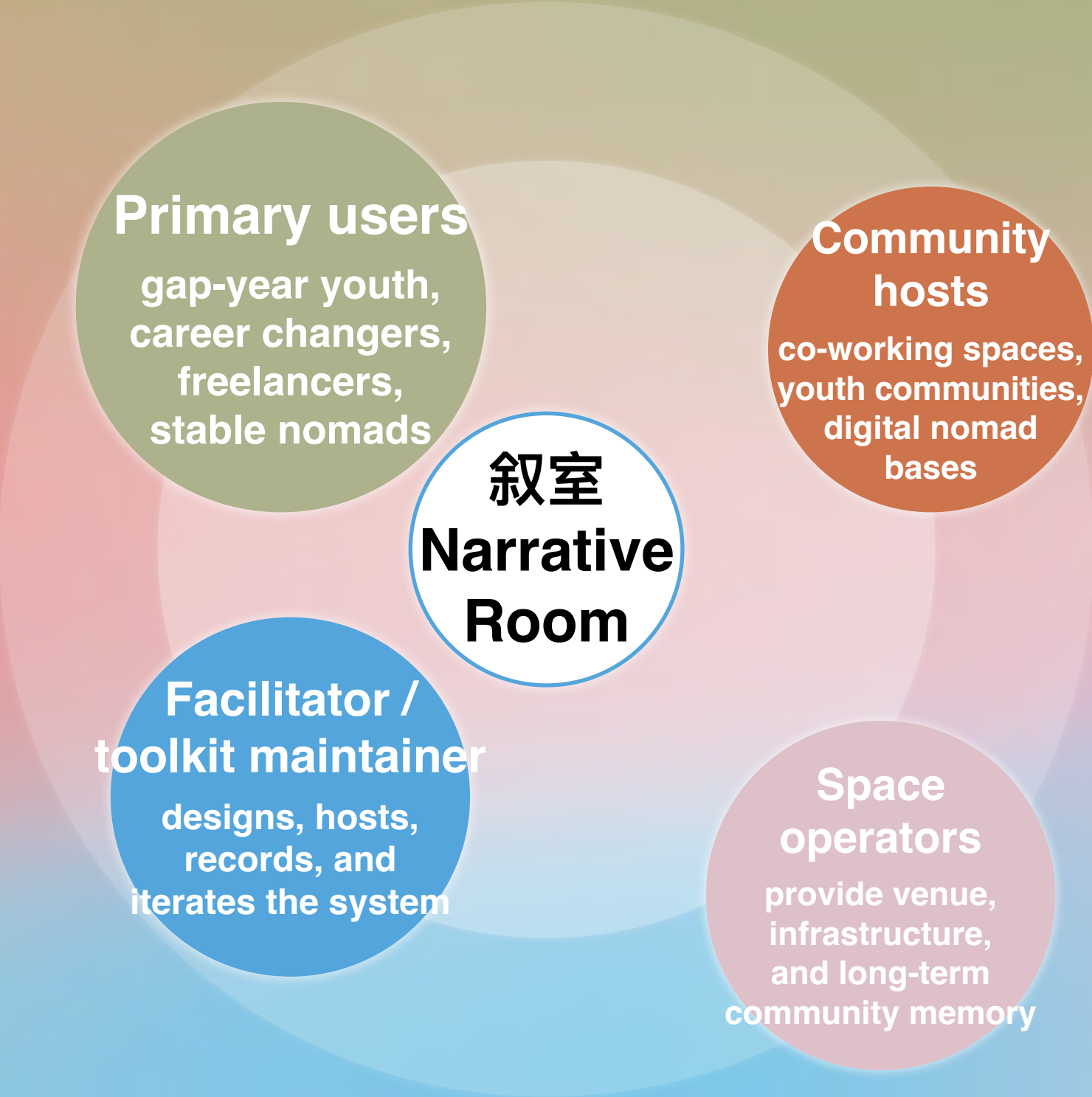
Visible Recognition & Self-efficacy

Use small rituals, resonance stickers, and strength cards to make “being seen” visible.

Replicable Toolkit for Hosts

Compress the process into cards, scripts, spatial setup, and facilitation guidelines that community hosts can learn quickly.

Key Stakeholders



Service System & Application Scenarios

Service System

Stage	Main Touchpoints	Purpose
Before	recruitment post, sign-up form, activity notice	Set expectations, clarify boundaries, screen participants
During	cards, identity map, consent cards, timer, support map	Guide storytelling, peer mirroring, and connection-building
After	feedback form, records, follow-up co-working or review	Preserve insights and support possible future connections

Typical Application Scenarios

Youth communities / co-working spaces



For new member onboarding, community review, and relationship-building.

Digital nomad communities / residency spaces



For short-term encounters, co-working openings, and lightweight peer matching.

Universities / youth development institutions



For career exploration, graduation transition support, and peer-support groups.

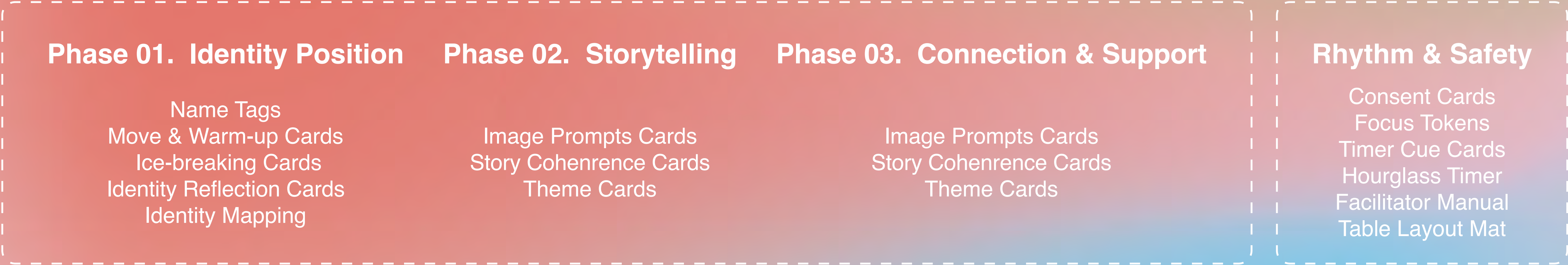
Co-creation / project incubation settings



For partner matching, resource exchange, and small collaboration starts.

Card System & Service Journey

Card System



Card System & Service Journey

Card System

Phase 01. Identity Position

Name Tags



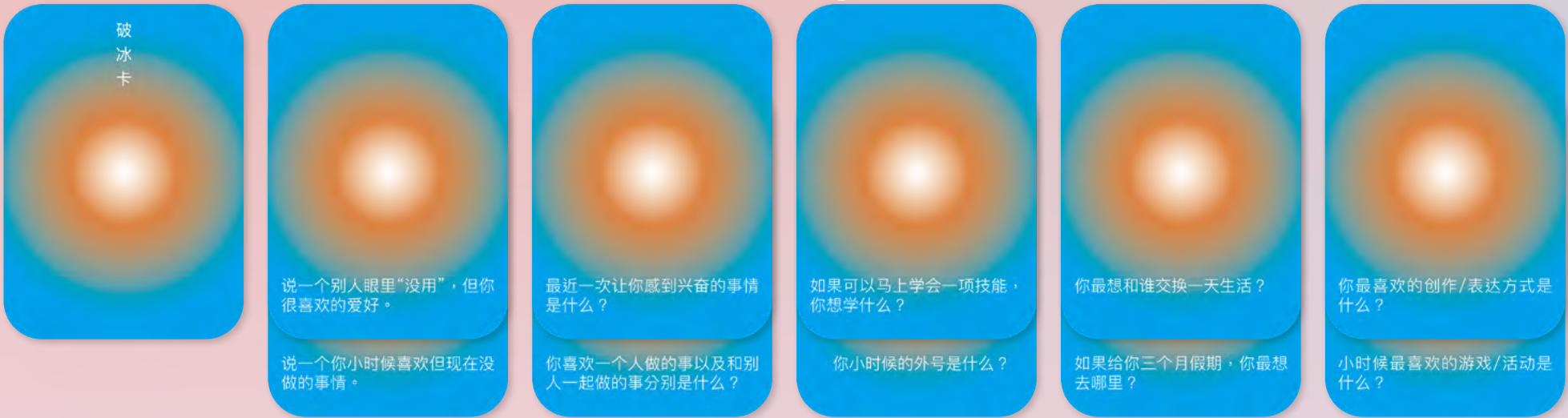
Identity Reflection Cards



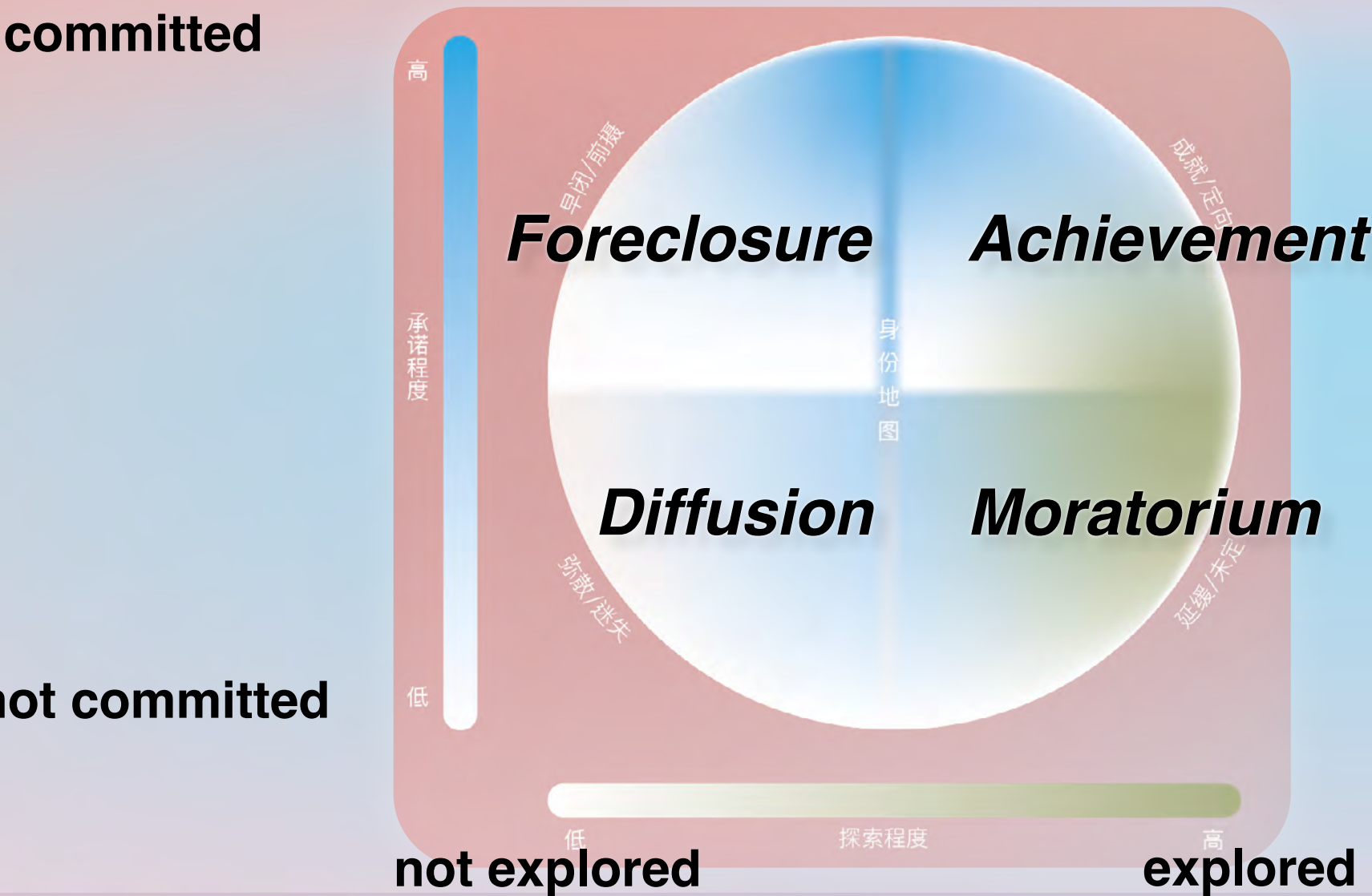
Move & Warm-up Cards



Ice-breaking Cards



Identity Mapping



Card System & Service Journey

Card System

Phase 02. Storytelling

Image Prompts Cards



Story Coherence Cards



Themes Cards



Card System & Service Journey

Card System

Phase 03. Connection & Support

Strength Cards

优势词库卡

行动与执行

- 果断
- 持续
- 节奏感
- 可靠
- 自驱
- 敏捷开工
- 时间感
- 复盘力
- 优先级清晰
-

认知与结构

- 条理清晰
- 系统化
- 抽象力
- 洞察
- 因果感
- 归纳整合
- 问题分解
- 抓要点
- 决策感
- 全局视角
-

学习与成长

- 好奇心
- 自学力
- 快速迭代
- 求反馈
- 跨学科学习
- 记录习惯
- 从错中学
- 练习耐心
- 持续打磨
- 探索勇气
-

沟通与叙事

- 深度聆听
- 共情力
- 复述力
- 讲故事
- 提问力
- 清晰表达
- 说服力
- 共识对齐
- 框架输出
- 可视化表达
- 主持控场
-

关系与协作

- 可信赖
- 稳定同伴
- 促成者
- 资源连接
- 协同意识
- 分工清楚
- 边界感
- 支持感
- 氛围营造
- 冲突缓解
- 欣赏他人
-

创造与审美

- 发散思考
- 灵感捕手
- 迭代小样
- 细节敏感
- 实验精神
- 勇于翻新
- 善用偶然
- 品味讲究
-

情绪与自我管理

- 自我觉察
- 情绪稳定
- 复原力
- 温柔坚定
- 勇于求助
- 专注力
- 节奏自护
- 边界表达
- 价值感
- 耐挫
- 沉着冷静
-

"I Notice..."

我看见了

提示：我看见你在...（情景）做了（行为），这让我看见（影响）...

我看见了

提示：我看见你在...（情景）做了（行为），这让我看见（影响）...

我看见了

提示：我看见你在...（情景）做了（行为），这让我看见（影响）...

我看见了

提示：我看见你在...（情景）做了（行为），这让我看见（影响）...

我看见了

提示：我看见你在...（情景）做了（行为），这让我看见（影响）...

我看见了

提示：我看见你在...（情景）做了（行为），这让我看见（影响）...

Support Cards

支援卡

我能提供：

我在找：



Card System & Service Journey

Six-step Service Journey

Phase	Time	Function
Recruitment & Screening	Before	Focus participants and clarify boundaries
Entry & Framing	0–15’	Build safety, break ice, map identity states
Narrative Experiment	15–40’	Use images and plot spine to tell turning-point stories
Meaning Deepening	40–60’	Link stories to identity, strengths, and themes
Connection & Matching	60–85’	Exchange support and identify possible companions
Closing & Reflection	85–100’	Leave visible traces, feedback, and one small next step

Final Design Output



User Testing & Feedback

Testing Setup

The final prototype was tested through one online pilot and two offline sessions to evaluate the card system across different media environments.

Format	Participants	Setting	Focus
Online pilot	3	Tencent Meeting + Miro	Remote usability and interaction logic
Offline pilot	5	Liangzhu 706 Living Room	Storytelling depth, peer interaction, and connection quality



Evaluation Dimensions

Process clarity & rhythm

Whether the flow was understandable and executable.

Narrative support

Whether cards helped participants move from experience to meaning.

Being seen & psychological safety

Whether participants felt heard, respected, and emotionally safe.

Connection & mutual support

Whether the process created possibilities for peer support.

Key Feedback

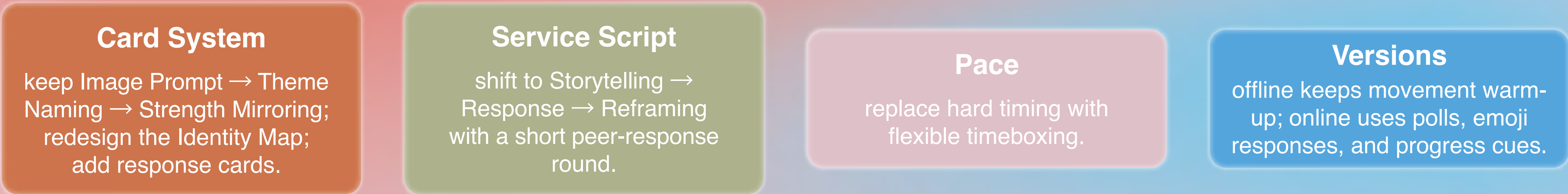
Image prompts, theme cards, and strength mirroring worked best.
The experience felt safe, opening, and emotionally supportive.
Its core value was structured self-clarification, not game competition or instant problem-solving.

Findings & Iteration Directions

Key Findings

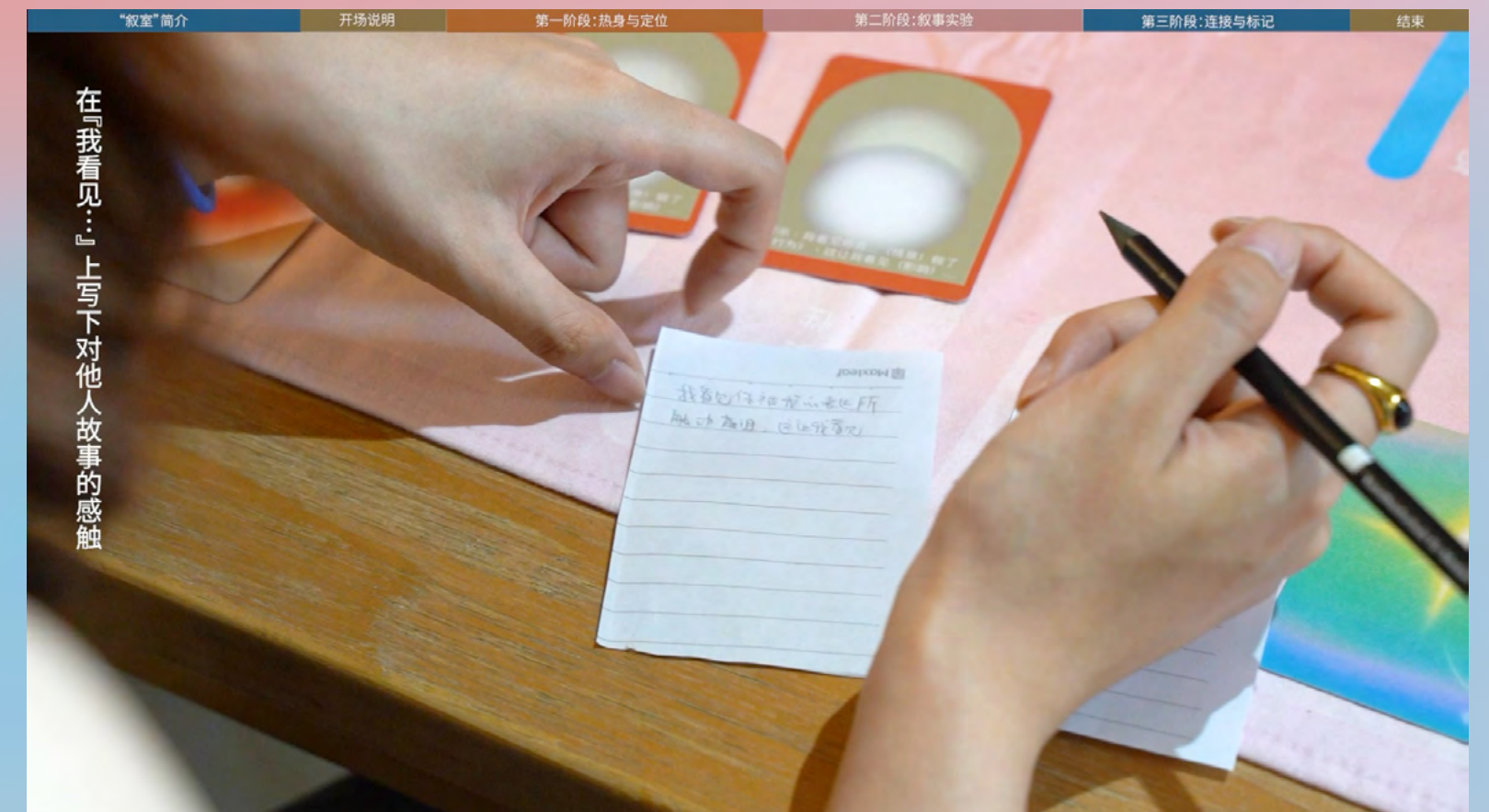


Prototype Iteration Directions



Watch the Video: Narrative Room Service Experience

03 Design Concept



Youtube: https://youtu.be/s9RW4ZzLFRM?si=rCXthVdKpVIF_wPB

Bilibili: https://www.bilibili.com/video/BV1dT5j6kEW8/?share_source=copy_web&vd_source=55c80e61b368999fad246d4e1b8be00f



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